

Impact Low · Difficulty Hard · Misuse risk It curdles into policing other people's humour, or over-correcting into stiffness that

THE MOVE

Care before clever: notice the joke impulse, check kindness, timing, and consent, choose the lowest-risk warm move, then repair fast if it misses. -> One-line rule: if the joke protects you more than it supports them, do not say it. -> Replacement ?

START HERE

When you feel the joke forming, pause for one beat and ask yourself: is this kind, timely, and wanted? If it is not a clear yes, offer a warm acknowledgement instead.

SAY THIS

Naming the pause	"I nearly made a joke there — I won't."
Warmth instead of a j...	"I was about to make a joke, but this sounds like it actually matters."
Keeping work mome...	"Let me not joke past the point. What's the main concern?"
Under pressure	"This is not a punchline moment. What do we need to decide?"
When a joke misses	"That came out more joking than I intended. Let me try again properly."
Grief, apology, and c...	"No jokes from me here. I'm sorry for the impact."

AVOID

- The relationship already has established playful trust
- The other person initiates the humour
- The joke is clearly self-light, gentle, and non-defensive

REMEMBER

A joke is optional; dignity is not.